A C K N O W L E D G M E N T S

I began learning Arabic in kindergarten, when the Arabs of Balad-a-Sheikh, which later became Tel Hanan, would come to pick olives from the trees in the yard of our cabin in Nesher every year during the harvest season. Perhaps this is the reason that in tenth grade I chose to specialize in Middle Eastern studies and was a graduate of the first class of this track in Israel. When I started university following my military service, it was only natural for me to study Arabic language and literature and Middle Eastern history. From there to the Mossad the road was short. The path to becoming the director of the Mossad was much longer.

Preceded by six Mossad heads—Reuven Shiloah, Isser Harel, Meir Amit, Zvi Zamir, Yitzhak ("Haka") Hofi, and Nahum Admoni—I was the first Mossad director that was not a member of the 1948 generation. I never knew Reuven Shiloah. I met Isser Harel only once I had already become director of the Mossad; and I worked with the other four directors quite closely throughout my years in the Mossad. They were role models and mentors to me, and I am grateful to them for everything they taught me. I am especially grateful to Nahum Admoni, to whom I owe, to a great extent, my appointment to the position.

Among the events that took place during my tenure as head of the Mossad (1989–96) were the collapse of the Soviet Union and the end of the Cold War era; the First Gulf War and Prime Minister Yitzhak Shamir's navigation of the state and the Israel Defense Forces through it; the peace agreement with Jordan, in which the Mossad played a central role; and the assassination of Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin.

I had the great privilege of working for the Mossad for thirty-two years, seven of them as director. The Mossad has always been a sanctuary within the beleaguered State of Israel, from the War of Independence until today. It would be impossible to cover all of the organization's achievements, but